

Well Spotted

One morning Ben **woke up** feeling **strange**. He had a headache and was **itchy** all over. He was covered in big red spots.

"Mum, Mum! Come and see," he **called out**. His mother **poked her head round the door**.

"What's the matter? Oh dear," she said. "It looks like chicken pox. No school for you today. It's highly **infectious**. Luckily I've had it and so has Dad. You can't catch it again if you've had it once."

"But what about Mrs McDonald's birthday?"

Mrs McDonald was an old lady who lived two houses away. She was nearly Ben's best friend, apart from Suki the cat and Jon from school who came and played most weekends. He had known Mrs McDonald since he was a baby and today was her birthday. Ben had made a card and they were all going to take her a **present** that evening.

Ben's dad had joined them. "Sorry chum, can't have you infecting Mrs McDonald. She may not have had chicken pox, or it may be so long ago she can't remember. Mum and me will just take the things and give her your love." He **peered** at Ben's spots. "You look terrible! Still, be positive," he said **cheerily** and went off to the office.

The day wasn't much fun. Television was boring and Ben knew all his old computer games backwards. He wrote Mrs McDonald a letter saying how sorry he was not to see her on her birthday.

Dad came home with a new computer game which was mega good and made things a lot better. While he was playing Mum came into his room.

"We are taking our presents to Mrs McDonald. I baked her a cake and I've left a little one downstairs for you. Phone if there's any trouble. The number's by the cake. See you in twenty minutes."

The door **slammed** and Ben went back to his computer game. After a little while he heard a crash and breaking glass downstairs. "Oh no, Suki's broken something," he **muttered** getting up. There was another bang and a **scrabbling** noise. Ben was on the stairs. The living room door was open.



Inside a man with a shaven head and wearing a hoodie jacket and dirty jeans was pushing things into a **sack**. He looked up, holding Dad's county golf champion silver cup in his hand.

"Don't come near, kid and you'll be all right," he **sarled**.

Ben was **trembling**, his palms wet and sticky. Be positive, think of something! Trying to keep his voice **steady**, he said, "Will you be all right? I'm really infectious! There are twenty-seven spots on my face and those are only the ones I could see in the mirror."

The **burglar** looked sharply at Ben's spotty face.

"Blimey, what have you got?" he asked.

"Chicken pox. My mum says it's really bad for grown-ups. Puts them in bed for weeks. But you won't get it if you've had it already. Have you had it?"

"No I haven't. Don't come near."

Ben advanced, the burglar backed away.

"Right, okay. I'll be off. See you," he said picking up his sack.

"I'd not take those things," said Ben. "Mum says people catch chicken pox from sneezes. I've been sneezing all over the place. There must be lots of germs on our stuff. You could get really sick."



The burglar threw down his sack. "Right, right, okay, you win. Just don't sneeze until I'm gone." He **crunched** through broken glass on the floor and climbed out of the open window. Ben heard his footsteps running away down the side **passage** between houses.

Phew! Ben went into the kitchen to find a dustpan and brush to **sweep up** the glass. A chocolate cake was sitting on the worktop with a knife beside it. He cut himself a slice. Then the phone rang. It was Dad.

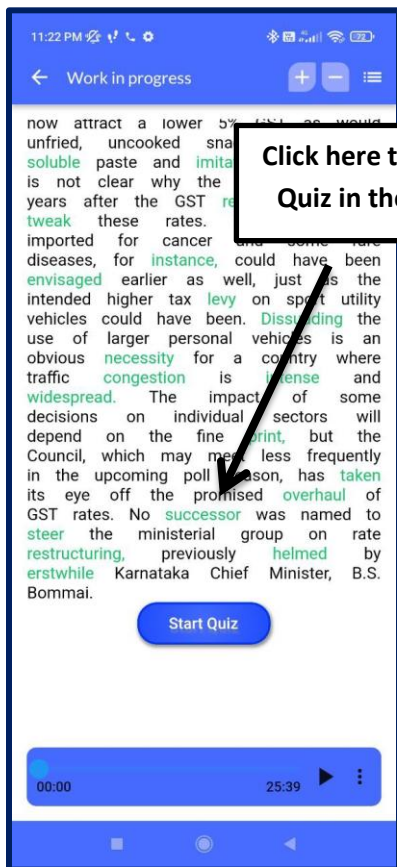
"Hi Ben! Mrs M would like a word." There was a scratching and a clicking and instructions from Ben's dad in the background, and then: "Hello Ben, thank you so much for the lovely card and letter and the presents. Are you all right all by yourself over there?"

"No problems," said Ben through a **mouthful** of chocolate cake.

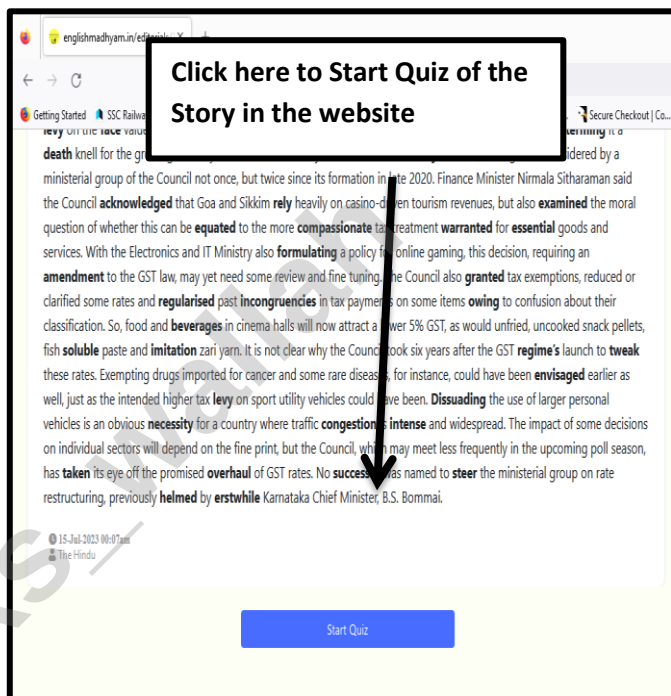
Vocabulary

1. **Wake up** (phrasal verb) – arise, get up, come to, rouse, stir – जागना
2. **Strange** (adjective) – unusual, odd, weird, peculiar, unfamiliar – अजीब
3. **Itchy** (adjective) – irritated, scratchy, ticklish, prickly, inflamed – खुजलीदार
4. **Call out** (phrasal verb) – shout, yell, cry, exclaim, summon – पुकारना / जोर से बोलना
5. **Poke one's head round the door** (phrase) – peek in, glance in, look in, peer in, crane in – झाँकना
6. **Infectious** (adjective) – contagious, communicable, transmittable, catching, spreading – संक्रामक
7. **Present** (noun) – gift, offering, token, donation, surprise – उपहार
8. **Peer** (verb) – look closely, gaze, scrutinize, examine, stare – ध्यान से देखना
9. **Cheerily** (adverb) – happily, brightly, joyfully, merrily, optimistically – प्रसन्नतापूर्वक
10. **Slam** (verb) – bang, shut forcefully, crash, clatter, thump – जोर से बंद करना
11. **Mutter** (verb) – murmur, mumble, whisper, grumble, speak low – बड़बड़ाना
12. **Scrabbling** (adjective) – scrambling, scratching, scuffling, groping, clawing – खरोंचता हुआ / घसीटता हुआ
13. **Sack** (noun) – bag, sackcloth, knapsack, bundle, pouch – बोरी / थैला
14. **Snarl** (verb) – growl, bark, snap, hiss, speak harshly – गुर्राणा / गुस्से से बोलना
15. **Trembling** (adjective) – shaking, quivering, shivering, shuddering, jittery – कांपता हुआ
16. **Steady** (adjective) – stable, firm, calm, balanced, controlled – स्थिर / संतुलित
17. **Burglar** (noun) – thief, intruder, robber, housebreaker, crook – चोर / सैधमार
18. **Crunch** (verb) – crush, crackle, grind, creak, trample – चरमराना / टूटना
19. **Passage** (noun) – corridor, hallway, alley, walkway, channel – मार्ग / गलियारा
20. **Sweep up** (phrasal verb) – clean up, gather, brush away, remove, tidy – साफ करना / बुहारना
21. **Mouthful** (adjective) – full bite, chunk, gobful, morsel, portion – मुंह भर (खाने की मात्रा)

Practice Exercise



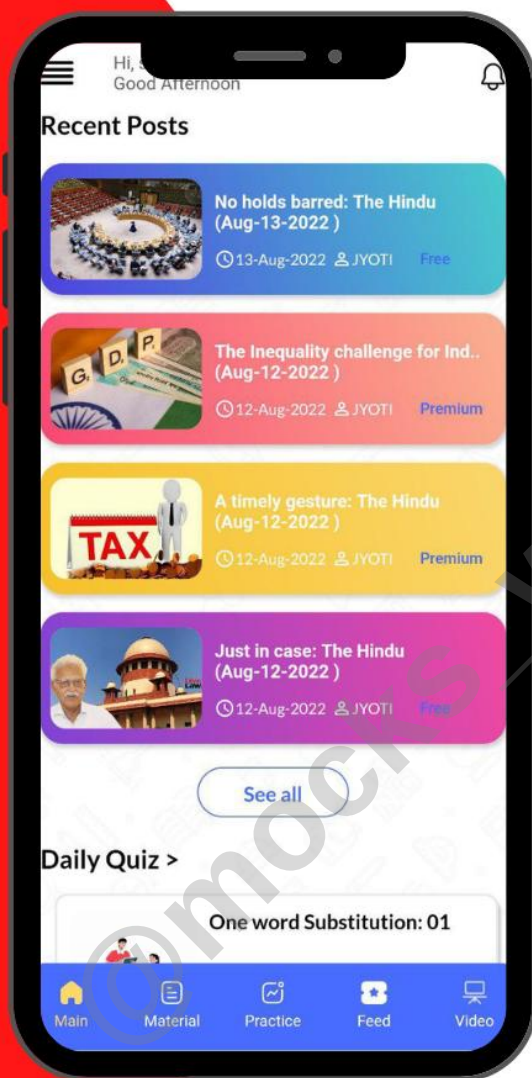
Click here to Start
Quiz in the App



Click here to Start Quiz of the
Story in the website

[Click here to download App](#)

[Click here to visit website](#)



Learn Vocabulary Through Reading Articles

English Madhyam